Drugs for Life - Joseph Dumit

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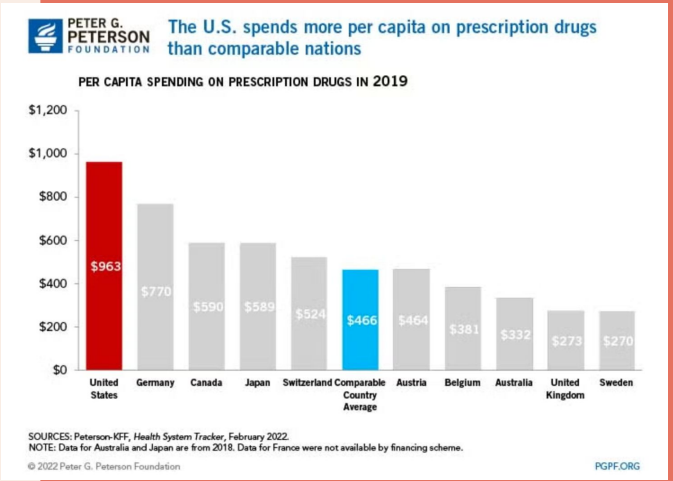
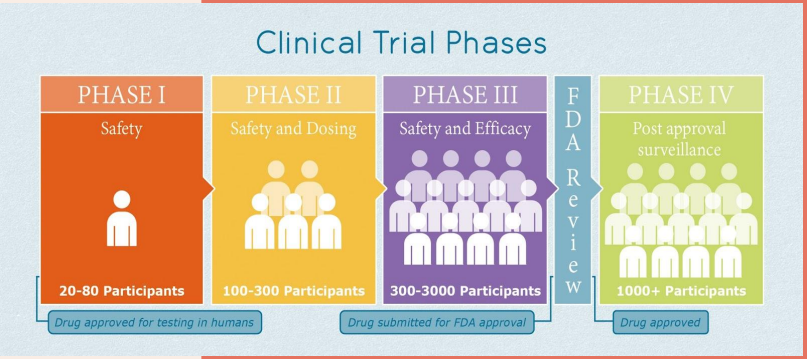
Rise of Prescription Drugs

- The average American fills 9-13 prescription drugs per year
- Over 4 billion prescriptions were written in 2011 alone
- Modern medicine focuses on managing risk rather than curing disease
    - Many medications are designed to be taken chronically rather than temporarily



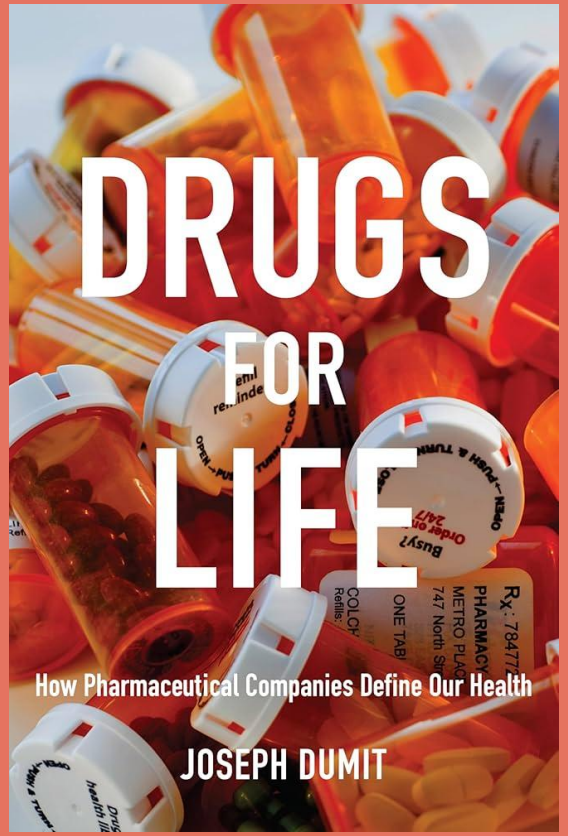
Clinical Trials

- Pharmaceutical companies profit from drugs that have patents and FDA approval
- Clinical trials provide the evidence needed for the FDA approval
- Patents enable companies to sell drugs exclusively for up to 14 years
- So, companies prioritize drugs with large potential markets
- Chronic treatment drugs = most profit
- Constant pipeline of new drugs tested through clinical trials



New Notion of Health

- Dumit argues that the pharmaceutical industry has developed a new notion of health (beginning in the 1960s)
  - Bodies are inherently ill (instead of inherently healthy) → due to genetics, lifestyles, trauma
- Chronically ill people are never absolutely healthy
  - Health is no longer an existential term
  - It's a temporal, relative, experiential term/feeling
- Majority of today's illnesses are treated as chronic
  - Being at risk for illness is often treated like having a disease that requires lifelong treatment (needing drugs for life)



Egoism

What Is *Truly* in Our Self -Interest?

- Ethical egoism is acting in <u>your own self-interest</u>
- Socrates questions this idea, that desires ≠ interests, and self-interest is not simply doing whatever we want
- The good life means protecting long-term well-being, not just satisfying wants
- Desires are what we want *right now* vs interests are what supports our *long term well being*

Desires

V.s.

Interests

Where Profit Replaces Health

Egoism in Big Pharma

- Joseph Dumit argues that pharmaceutical companies prioritize <u>profitability over medical need</u> when deciding which drugs to develop
  - Conflict between short-term profit (desire) vs long-term societal health (interest)
- Pharma companies may pursue drugs that:
  - Treat large markets rather than the most urgent illnesses
  - Generate higher revenue rather than greatest health benefit

> “Health is thereby structurally subordinate to profit.”
> (Dumit 92)

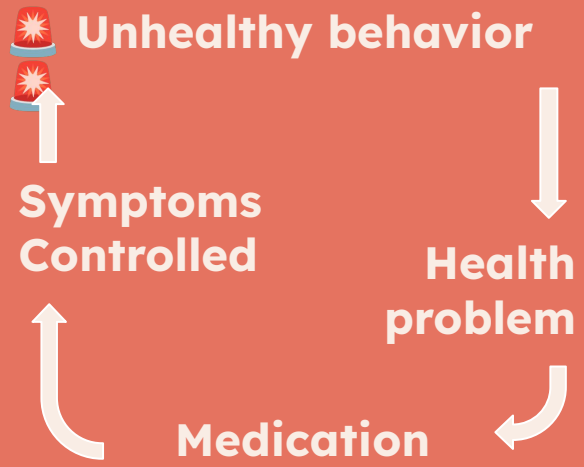
E.g. **Cholesterol Drugs**

Multiple drugs very similar to each other so they count as a new drug for regulatory approval → treat the same large market

So Does Medicine Support Our *Desires*?

- Pharmaceuticals allow people to maintain unhealthy behaviors while managing the consequences
  - An obese diabetic "continues to indulge his weakness of heart-stopping entrees," while taking medication to control the condition. (Dumit 192)
  - The root cause is not addressed!
- Health becomes something that is managed with treatment, rather than achieved through lifestyle change.

My Depiction of the Pharmaceutical Cycle



So Does Medicine Support Our *Desires*?

- Pharmaceuticals have forced people to reshape themselves as not just healthy individuals, but patients managing biological risks.
  - "...average American is prescribed a between nine and thirteen prescription-only drugs per year" (Dumit 11)

Through this system, the goal has become to increase treatments rather than reduce. "No one is thinking about the patients, just market share." (Dumit 17)

Advertisement by Pfizer, credit to *Drugs and Life* (Dumit 11)

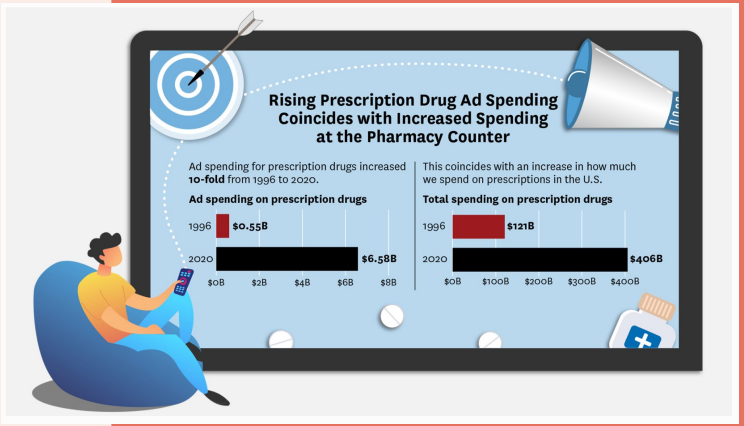
Kantianism

- Faustian Bargain - exchanging something of moral importance for worldly gains
- Pharmaceutical Companies:
  - Sacrifice transparency
  - Sacrifice factual integrity
  - in pursuit of profit
- Directly in conflict with Kantian ethics
  - Acting out of moral duty

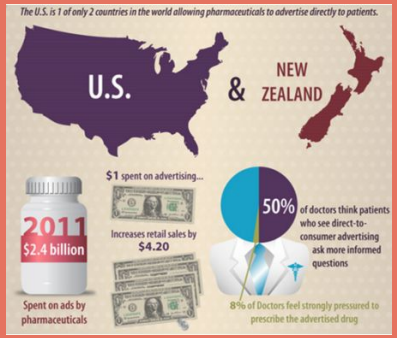
“Always treat people as ends in themselves, never as means to an end” - Immanuel Kant

Antidepressants and Policy Decisions

- Dumit describes how different institutions interpreted the same scientific evidence differently:
- Evidence that SSRIs (selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors) linked to increased suicide in children
  - British gov: banned SSRIs (except Prozac)
  - United States: resulted only in warning rather than ban
- Market interests prioritized over moral duty



Antidepressants and Policy Decisions

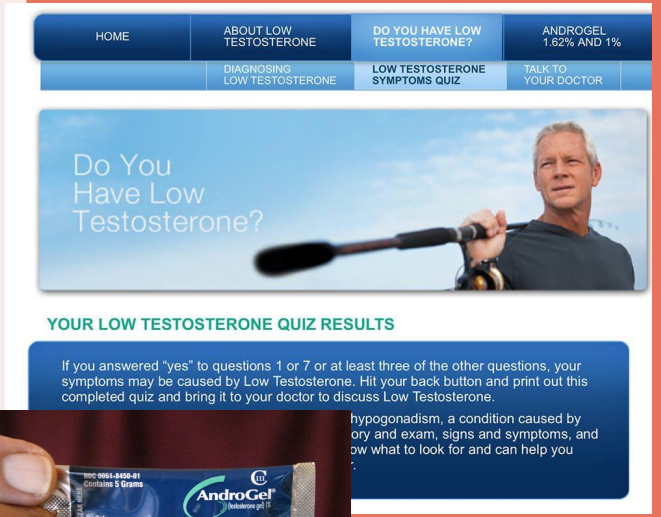


British Approach	American Approach
• Greater skepticism towards adopting new medical technologies and treatments (eg: MRIs, CAT scans) • Direct-to-consumer pharmaceutical advertising is banned • National Health Service determines what medications are purchased and prescribed • Treatment decisions institutionally regulated	• More rapid adoption of new medical technologies and pharmaceutical treatments • Direct-to-consumer drug advertising is allowed • Patients have greater autonomy in choosing doctors, negotiating treatments, etc. • Medication favored over psychotherapy because pills are cheaper

Source: https://www.nytimes.com/2004/05/25/health/commentary-antidepressants-two-countries-two-views.html

“Strategic Ubiquity” in Marketing

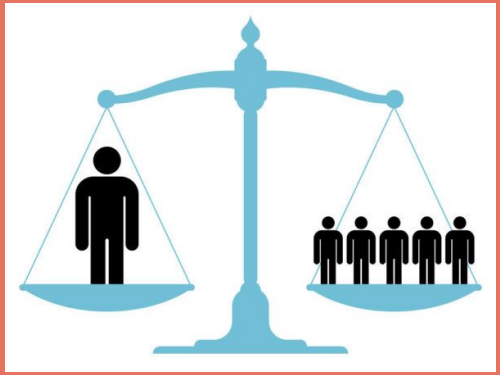
- Patients typically consult multiple online sources when researching a drug or possible diagnoses
- “Companies create a network of sponsored content, advocacy partnerships and third-party platforms presenting the same information” (Dumit, 41)
- Eg: Low “T” Testosterone Campaign
  - 2008, Company: AbbVie
  - Symptoms: fatigue, low libido, mood changes = signs of medical condition
  - Ads and online quizzes encouraged men to ask doctors about AndroGel
  - 2012: $80 million ads -> $1 billion sales



Source: https://www.cochranfirm.com/washington-dc/practice-areas/defective-recalled-products/testosterone-replacement-therapy/androgel/

Utilitarianism

- Utilitarianism: determines moral worth by how an entity can bring the most happiness to the most people
  - Greatest Happiness Principle (GHP): an action is best if it procures the greatest happiness
- Pharma companies test and compare drug efficacy in statistically rigorous clinical trials
  - Claim that this is to maximize welfare in public health by innovating medication
- But clinical trials are funded and run by for-profit companies - do clinical trial outcomes increase or decrease overall welfare?



Drug Development

- Clinical trials are investments for companies
- Dumit explains:
  - Pharma companies target preventative care and risk factors to create drugs that have the greatest market possible (e.g. high cholesterol)
  - Target chronic illnesses that are treatable for life (e.g. mental illness, diabetes)
  - These medications aren't curative → are meant to be taken long term for symptom treatment or preventative measures

Neglected Tropical Diseases (NTDs)

- Pharma companies are less incentivized to research one-time medicines
  - E.g. vaccines decrease the spread of a disease → reduce demand for the product
  - This doesn't apply GHP → since research doesn't maximize total reduction of suffering globally
- Neglected tropical diseases (NTDs): diseases with historically underfunded curative research (WHO)
  - Group of conditions caused by various pathogens (viruses, bacteria, parasites, etc.)
  - Prevalent among impoverished communities in tropical areas

NTDs affect ~1 billion people (~1/8 of the world's population)

~1.495 billion need preventative and curative care

Per year, approx. 120k deaths and 14.1 million disability adjusted life years (DALYs) lost

Patent Protected Production

- Large-scale clinical trials do distinguishing drug efficacy
  - Compare treatment outcomes between different drugs (or different drug formulations)
- Under patent coverage (up to 14 years), pharma companies can charge non-competitive (temporary monopoly) rates

Insulin Prices

- In 2022, gross insulin prices in the U.S. were ~10x higher than in other 33 OECD comparison countries, countries with relatively comparable economies (RAND)
  - U.S. net prices (taking into account insurance) were 2.33x higher than comparison countries
- 9 insulin products sold only in the U.S. and 53 insulin products sold only in non-U.S. OECD comparison countries
  - Meaning that in the U.S., patients are likely switched to newer products (under patent coverage) and older products are discontinued
  - Ex: 2024 discontinuation of Levemir in the U.S. by Novo Nordisk, after primary patent expiration in 2019

Capitalism & Innovation

- Gaining FDA approval is lengthy and running clinical trials is expensive
  - For-profit companies do actually fund drug development ⇒ pharmaceutical innovation can increase life expectancy
  - Ex: Merck funded large scale clinical trials for lovastatin (cholesterol medication)
  - Ex: 5 pharmaceutical companies contributed to production research for penicillin during WWII
    - Penicillin still considered a vital, first-line antibiotic to treat bacterial infections
    - Abbott Laboratories, Pfizer (Lederle Laboratories, Chas. Pfizer & Co), Merck., and E.R. Squibb & Sons
- Key feature of capitalist/free market systems:
  - Profit is main motivation for companies
  - GHP: can lead to innovation and wide-reaching increases in happiness/survival for many people

Existentialism

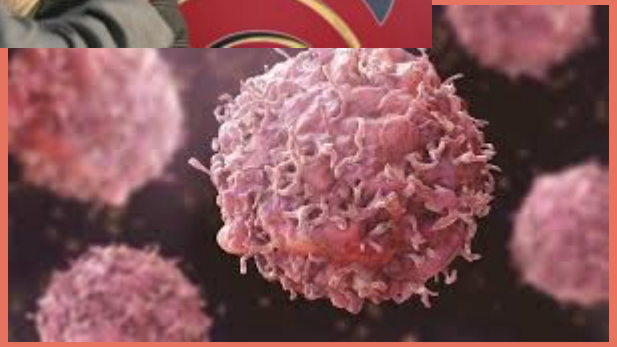
The Freedom of Choice

- We each create our own values
  - Includes seeing the value in each prescription
- The patients at the end of the day must be able to live with their consequences
- People are still sharing home remedies, exploring alternative medicine, getting second opinions, etc.

"11 million Americans currently take… [cholesterol medication]… while some public health experts say that at least 36 million should **probably** be on one" (Wall Street Journal, 2004)

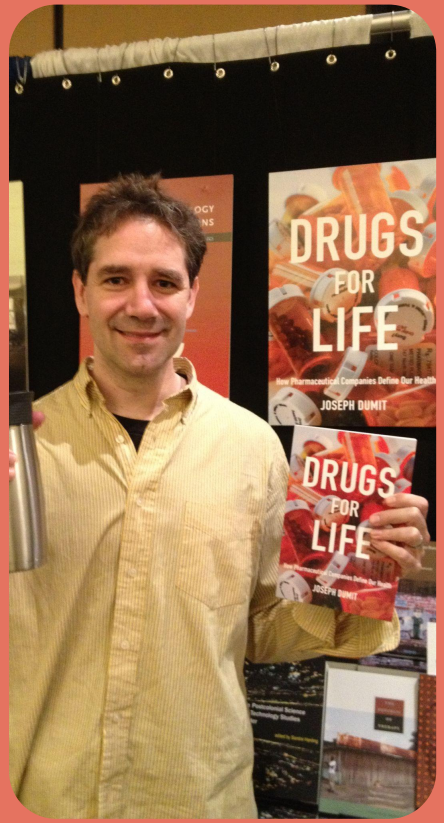
The Perceived Marketed Choice

- AT RISK DOES NOT MEAN ILLNESS
- The general public is made to be default ill instead of default healthy
- Fear sways judgement
  - Andy Grove - doctors telling him diagnosis in a way they want him to interpret it
- Truman show - Marketing dream
  - get influenced by everything, no element of choice



Conclusions

- Dumit believes that the clinical trials used to approve drugs don't ask questions that doctors care about, like when the patient should stop taking the drug, or what the long-term effects are
  - Phase IV trials don't occur usually
- While ads are a big driver for Big Pharma, so are: clinical trial design, medical guidelines, and public relations campaigns (maximizing prescriptions rather than understanding long-term effects



Class Reflections

This class made ethics feel much more tangible to me. I liked being able to connect the theories we learned to areas like medicine, AI, and tech, because those are all spaces where people are constantly making decisions with real consequences. Ethics is not just an abstract philosophical idea, but deeply relevant to systems we live in!

- Diya

Throughout the class I have re-evaluated myself as a person. I have grown to see my choices through different ethical perspectives and be able to apply those perspectives to my everyday life.

- Deema

Discussion Q1

What is the solution then? **Aren't those ads on tv the real problem?**

Dumit suggests that TV ads certainly sway the public's opinion of medication, but the real issue is how the industry redefines what we see as healthy

Discussion Q2

If modern medicine focuses on treatment rather than holistic wellness, **why don't we turn to *alternative medicine* for taking care of ourselves?**

Common types of alternative medicine: acupuncture, ayurvedic practice, herbal remedies, Chinese medicine

Dumit suggests that even alternative medicine often follows the same logic as pharmaceuticals. People take herbs because there is shown to be a small reduction in health risks, and this creates the same pattern of more risk → more treatment → more substances